



△ ANT FEAST

A giant anteater feeds from one anthill only for a few moments before moving on to the next to ensure it does not exhaust its food supply.

◁ KNUCKLE-WALKER

Giant anteaters have a shuffling gait. They walk on the knuckles of their forelimbs whereas they keep the heels of their hindlimbs on the ground.

Patagonian mara

Dolichotis patagonum



A mara looks like a small deer when on the move. When seated on its haunches, it could be mistaken for a giant rabbit. It is, however, a large, long-legged relative of the cavy, or guinea pig. Maras live in arid grasslands, where they spend the day grazing on sparse shoots and herbs. As temperatures drop at night, they retreat to burrows, which they dig using

the sharp claws on their forefeet. While foraging, maras are preyed upon by foxes, pampas cats, and birds of prey. In defense, they operate in pairs—a male and female that stay together for life. While one feeds, the other keeps watch. If a threat is spotted, they gallop away, reaching a top speed of 28 mph (45 km/h).

↔ 27–30 in (69–75 cm)

⚖ 20–35 lb (9–16 kg)

⊗ Near threatened

🌿 Grasses, herbs, seeds



S. South
America



◁ LIFE IN A COMMUNE

Maras give birth in summer, which is also the rainy season. Pups are born in communal burrows occupied by several breeding pairs.

Six-banded armadillo

Euphractus sexcinctus

This native of the savannas digs out most of its food, such as roots, with its large forefeet. It also eats fallen fruit and licks up ants with its long, feathery tongue. The six-banded armadillo lives alone in burrows it digs about three feet into the

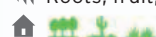
ground. Marking territory with scent from a gland under the tail, it bites and scratches other armadillos that stray inside. The armadillo is a good swimmer, and swallows air before entering water to aid its buoyancy.

↔ 16–20 in (40–50 cm)

⚖ 7–14 lb (3.2–6.5 kg)

⊗ Common

🌿 Roots, fruit, insects, carrion



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▽ BODY ARMOR

The armadillo buries itself when it spots predators. The armored body plates protect any exposed upper body part, while the armadillo wedges itself into its burrow.

six-banded
armadillos have
six, seven, or
eight bands



long, bushy,
brown tail